

The Front RUNNERS

It is a loose grouping of super-sized egos and prime ministerial ambitions with no ideological common ground. Welcome to the strange universe of the Third Way.

| By Shafi Rahman |

In the ever-shifting matrix of co-habitation politics, even a brief cigarette break can change the terms of endearment. Certain gossipy comrades tell the story of how the sinful tobacco camaraderie between West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya and his counterpart from Orissa, Naveen Patnaik, at the chief ministers' meetings in Delhi made it easier for the BJP to desert the NDA and join that amorphous entity called the Third Front. But much before the smoke signals emerged from Bhubaneswar, the CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat, badly scalded by nuclear emissions from the UPA Government that sold its soul to the US imperium, was at work as head-hunter. Thanks to the chief apparatchik's new-found skills in talent-spotting, the Third Alternative has grown from a Karat-Mayawati romance into a suspense thriller populated by such regional heavyweights like Deve Gowda (JD-S).

Chandrababu Naidu (TDP) and J. Jayalalithaa (AIADMK). And, as if this eruption of provincial power is not enough to remind us of the limits of bipolarity in Indian politics, there is now even a Fourth Front consisting of the toxic assets offloaded by the Congress. The erstwhile socialists of the heartland—Lalu Prasad Yadav,

Mulayam Singh Yadav and Ram Vilas Paswan—have suddenly discovered virtues in each other. Then there is the NCP leader Sharad Pawar, who, though officially in the UPA, is making friendly noises to all the fronts. Matinee idol and Andhra Pradesh's new political sensation Chiranjeevi is available at fire-

sale price. No democracy is unlikely to match us in this embarrassment of riches.

With the arena warming up, the Front will offer daredevil lifts, drops, slides, loops, swirls and wrap-rounds, stretching the limits of possibilities in the biggest show in politics. There will be no decency or chivalry on display as desperate leaders with super-sized egos aspire to be kingmakers, if not kings. They are not united by ideology but ambition—and an exaggerated sense of indispensability. Most of them have declared their independ-

**COMPETITIVE PROVINCIALISM HAS TURNED
THE 15TH LOK SABHA ELECTIONS INTO AN
ANTHOLOGY OF STATE ELECTIONS.**